Butternut Squash Yellow Curry

Aromatic jasmine rice starts in the rice cooker, then bone-in chicken leg quarters are pressure-cooked with curry paste and Better Than Bouillon. The strained broth seasons a coconut yellow curry of butternut squash and carrots; bite-size chicken and pineapple finish the pot with brown sugar, fish sauce, and lime. Serves 8.

Ingredients

Jasmine rice . . . . . 3 scoops
Coconut oil . . . . . 2½ Tbsp.
Bay leaf 1
Green cardamom pods 2
Better Than Bouillon, chicken . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Mae Ploy yellow curry paste . . . . . 8 Tbsp.
Bay leaf 1
Green cardamom pods 3
Chicken leg quarters, bone-in, skin-on . . . 4
White onions, large 2
Garlic cloves 8
Fresh ginger, minced . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Kosher salt . . . . . ¼ tsp.
Coconut cream . . . . . 2 (13.5 oz.) cans
Brown sugar . . . . . 4 Tbsp.
Fish sauce . . . . . 2 Tbsp.
Lemongrass stalks . . . . . 2 (optional)
Butternut squash 1
Carrots 4
Pineapple chunks . . . . . 1 (15 oz.) can
Dried holy basil . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Limes 2
Fresh cilantro, chopped . . . . . 1 cup
Salt . . . . . to taste

Directions

Peel, seed, and cut 1 **butternut squash** into 1" chunks — Peel and large-dice 4 **carrots** into ¾–1" pieces — Combine **squash** and **carrots** in *Large Bowl #1* — Large-dice 2 **white onions**; mince 8 **garlic cloves** and 1 Tbsp. **ginger**; combine in *Medium Bowl #1* — Juice 1 **lime**; wedge the other — Chop 1 cup **cilantro**

Rice

Wash 3 scoops **jasmine rice** until the water runs clear; drain. Cook in the rice cooker with 3 cups **water**, ½ Tbsp. **coconut oil**, 1 **bay leaf**, and 2 **green cardamom pods**. Leave on warm while you make the **chicken** and curry. Before serving, rest *5 minutes* if just finished, remove the 1 **bay leaf** and 2 **cardamom pods**, and fluff.

Chicken

1. Dissolve 1 Tbsp. **Better Than Bouillon** and 1 Tbsp. **curry paste** in 2 cups **hot water**.
2. Add 1 **bay leaf** and 3 **green cardamom pods** to a 6-quart Instant Pot. Place 4 **chicken leg quarters** on top and pour the mixture over the **chicken**. Seal the lid and set the valve to sealing. Cook on *high* pressure for *12 minutes*, then allow natural release for *10 minutes* before releasing any remaining pressure. **Chicken** is done when it reaches *165°F* at the thickest part near the bone and the meat pulls easily from the bone.
3. Transfer **chicken** to a cutting board and rest for about *10 minutes*, until cool enough to handle. Discard the skin. Pick the meat from the bones into bite-size chunks (some shredding is natural) and place in *Large Bowl #2*.
4. Strain the chicken broth through a fine-mesh strainer into a bowl, then skim the fat. Measure 2 cups of the skimmed broth into *Medium Bowl #2* for the curry. Refrigerate any remaining broth for another use.

Curry

1. Heat 2 Tbsp. **coconut oil** in a large Dutch oven over medium heat. Add **onions**, **garlic**, and **ginger** (*Medium Bowl #1*) with 1/4 tsp. **kosher salt** and cook, stirring often, until the **onions** are translucent and the aromatics are fragrant, about *6–8 minutes*. Do not brown.
2. Add 7 Tbsp. **Mae Ploy yellow curry paste** and cook, stirring constantly, until the paste darkens slightly and smells toasted and fragrant, about *2–3 minutes*.
3. Pour in about half of the first can of **coconut cream** and stir until the paste is smooth. Add the remaining **coconut cream** from both cans, 2 cups reserved broth (*Medium Bowl #2*), 4 Tbsp. **brown sugar**, 2 Tbsp. **fish sauce**, and 2 bruised **lemongrass stalks** if using. Stir and bring to a simmer.
4. Add **squash** and **carrots** (*Large Bowl #1*) and return to a gentle simmer. Cook uncovered, stirring occasionally, for about *15 minutes* until both are tender: a paring knife inserted into the center of a chunk meets no resistance, and pieces hold their shape but are soft. The sauce should coat the back of a spoon. Continue simmering in *2–3 minute* increments until the vegetables are tender.
5. Drain the **pineapple chunks** in the can. Add the picked **chicken** (*Large Bowl #2*), drained **pineapple**, and 1 Tbsp. **dried holy basil**. Simmer for *3–5 minutes* until the **chicken** is heated through and steaming hot throughout.
6. Remove the **lemongrass** if used. Taste and adjust seasoning with **salt** if needed. Stir in the juice of 1 **lime** and 1/2 cup of the chopped **cilantro**. Serve the curry over the fluffed **rice**, garnished with the remaining **cilantro** and **lime wedges**. The curry is best soon after finishing, while the sauce is glossy and the lime is bright.

Yield

- Serves 8

Equipment Required

- Rice cooker
- Instant Pot (6-quart)
- Large Dutch oven or heavy pot (6–7 quart capacity)
- Fine-mesh strainer (for washing rice and straining broth)
- Cutting board and chef's knife
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Wooden spoon or silicone spatula
- Rice paddle or fork
- Instant-read thermometer (for chicken)
- Tongs or slotted spoon
- Vegetable peeler
- Medium prep bowls (2)
- Large prep bowls (2)

Mise en Place

- Wash 3 scoops **jasmine rice** first; start the rice cooker before the Instant Pot
- Medium Bowl #1 — aromatics: large-dice **onions**, minced **garlic**, minced **ginger**
- Large Bowl #1 — vegetables: 1" **butternut squash** chunks and large-dice **carrots**
- Large Bowl #2 — picked bite-size **chicken** (after Instant Pot)
- Medium Bowl #2 — 2 cups strained, skimmed chicken broth
- Divide shared aromatics before cooking: ½ Tbsp. **coconut oil**, 1 **bay leaf**, and 2 **cardamom pods** for rice; 2 Tbsp. **coconut oil**, 1 **bay leaf**, and 3 **cardamom pods** for chicken/curry
- Juice 1 **lime** and wedge the other; chop 1 cup **cilantro** (½ cup for the curry, remainder for garnish)

Ingredient Tips

- Mae Ploy **yellow curry paste** is recommended; 8 Tbsp. total is intentional and assertive—taste and adjust with **coconut cream** or **brown sugar** if needed
- **Coconut cream** significantly improves body and richness; full-fat **coconut milk** is an acceptable substitute but yields a thinner, less luxurious curry
- **Brown sugar** (not palm) matches this tested balance with pineapple
- **Fish sauce** brands vary in saltiness; start with 2 Tbsp. and adjust at the end
- **Dried holy basil** adds herbal lift when stirred in at the finish
- Optional **lemongrass**: bruise the stalks with the flat of a knife before adding to the curry; remove before serving
- Bone-in, skin-on **leg quarters** yield richer Instant Pot broth; discard skin after cooking

Preparation Tips

- Cook in order: **rice** first, then Instant Pot **chicken**, then curry
- Wash **rice** until the water runs clear (*3–4 rinses*) so grains stay separate
- Fully dissolve **Better Than Bouillon** and the 1 Tbsp. **curry paste** in the 2 cups **hot water** before pouring over the **chicken**
- While the Instant Pot cooks, finish mise en place and measure the curry seasonings
- Bloom the remaining 7 Tbsp. **curry paste** until it darkens and smells toasted—raw paste tastes flat
- Uniform 1" **squash** and similar **carrot** pieces cook evenly; larger chunks need a few more minutes
- The Instant Pot cooks the **chicken** through; the final simmer only reheats it with pineapple
- Skim the chicken broth well so the curry is rich but not greasy
- Taste before serving; **lime juice** and **salt** balance the sweet coconut sauce

Make Ahead & Storage

- Curry can be made *1–2 days* ahead; flavors improve
- Store refrigerated up to *4 days*
- Reheat gently; thin with reserved Instant Pot broth or **coconut cream** if the sauce has thickened
- Add fresh **lime juice** and **cilantro** after reheating
- Extra Instant Pot broth keeps refrigerated *4–5 days* or freezes well
- Cooked **rice** keeps refrigerated *3–4 days*; reheat with a splash of water

Serving Suggestions

- Serve the curry over the aromatic rice-cooker **rice**
- **Lime wedges** and remaining **cilantro** at the table
- Fresh Thai basil at the table if available